AI | Expert Insights

VOICE OF CUSTOMER

Head of Strategic Partnerships at Accelerant Holdings Sees AI BPO Solutions as Effective but Notes Market Commoditization Trends

DATE PUBLISHED	INTERVIEW DATE	EXPERT PERSPECTIVE	ANALYST PERSPECTIVE	PRIMARY COMPANY
13 Aug 2026	11 Aug 2026	Customer	AI Interviewer	PACE (WITHPACE)

SMART SUMMARY

Summary

The interview covered the selection, implementation, and evaluation of an AI-driven BPO solution for insurance back office operations, including competitive landscape, pricing, and future outlook. The discussion also addressed product differentiation, service quality, and the potential for market commoditization.

EXPERT BACKGROUND

- Head of Strategic Partnerships at an insurance-focused organization, leading vendor management, strategic partnerships, and technology selection for new business verticals, with direct experience evaluating and implementing AI-driven BPO solutions.

EXPERT SENTIMENT

- Sees AI BPO solutions as effective and aligned with a forward-looking, technology-driven ethos, but views the market as increasingly commoditized and cost-driven.
- Believes current solutions meet expectations but are not irreplaceable; would consider switching if costs rise or competitors offer better value.
- Is **cautiously optimistic about the future of AI workflows** but expects to be surprised by added value to become truly excited.

TAKEAWAYS

- The organization implemented an AI BPO solution (Pace) to support a new business vertical requiring MGA-like back office operations, after evaluating both traditional and agentic BPO providers.
- Key decision factors included fit for purpose, price point, insurance domain expertise, and the ability to audit and control workflows.
- Implementation was straightforward, requiring about a month and a half, with integration into existing systems and minimal IT involvement.
- The usage-based pricing model is seen as cost-effective at scale compared to traditional BPOs, but ROI is still being determined due to early-stage utilization.
- **The expert sees the AI BPO market as highly competitive and likely to become commoditized**, with switching costs considered low and price increases above 3-5% likely to prompt a review of alternatives.

AlphaSense Assistant is AI Generated

Table of Contents

Introduction and Expert's Role

Usage of Pace in Operations

Decision to Adopt Pace

Competitive Landscape and Differentiation

Implementation and Integration Process

Service Quality and Pricing

Future Considerations and Expectations

Expert Bio

Head Of Strategic Partnerships at Accelerant Holdings. The expert is responsible for building out accretive ecosystem partnerships that serve Accelerant’s 250+ member MGAs. The expert cultivates long-term relationships with key distribution partners and managing general agents (MGAs) to drive growth within the specialized insurance market. The expert can speak on insurance, life insurance, personal insurance, auto insurance, commercial specialty insurance, and home insurance.

Interview Transcript

©2026, AlphaSense, Inc. All Rights Reserved. AlphaSense is a service mark of AlphaSense, Inc. All other trademarks mentioned belong to their respective owners.

AI Interviewer 00:00:00

Hi. Thanks for taking the time to talk with me. I am interested in learning more about your organization and what it does?

Expert 00:00:08

I work for a company called Accelerant. We provide access to capacity. We run what we call a risk exchange, where MGAs come to, again, get access to capacity. We also support them with various purpose-built technology as well as access to other technology providers, services, and resources that we create relationships with on their behalf.

AI Interviewer 00:00:32

That's really helpful context. What's your specific role there? How does it relate to Pace?

Expert 00:00:39

I run our strategic partnerships function. I lead vendor management or vendor selection processes, both internally but also on behalf of our MGAs. I lead what's called the Accelerant Marketplace, where we partner with various tools, technologies, resources to, again, provide that access to MGAs. I also help lead vendor management internally for new verticals or strategic priorities for our organization as well.

AI Interviewer 00:01:08

With that scope in mind, are you more of a decision-maker when it comes to Pace or more of a power user or both?

Expert 00:01:15

Decision-maker.

AI Interviewer 00:01:17

Got it. Which specific products or modules from Pace does your organization use?

Expert 00:01:22

We've licensed Pace to support underwriting workflows, so submission intelligence, triaging. We've also licensed their midterm policy management customer service workflow, so managing policy changes, policy endorsements, etc. We've also licensed their agentic claims workflow as well for taking in first notices of loss and things like that.

AI Interviewer 00:01:44

That's a pretty broad footprint. Which teams in your organization are actually using those modules day to day?

Expert 00:01:52

This was brought on for a new vertical at Accelerant that required more MGA-like operations, more of an MGA-like back office, which is a deviation from our standard day-to-day operations. We felt for this new strategy, we should be supported by a full suite of back-office tools, so the strategy team focused on this particular new vertical are the daily users of Pace.

AI Interviewer 00:02:16

Roughly how many people on that team are using Pace day to day?

Expert 00:02:23

Five people.

AI Interviewer 00:02:25

Does that represent most of that team or is it a subset?

Expert 00:02:29

It's most of that team.

©2026, AlphaSense, Inc. All Rights Reserved. AlphaSense is a service mark of AlphaSense, Inc. All other trademarks mentioned belong to their respective owners.

AI Interviewer 00:02:31
How long have you been working with Pace at this point?

Expert 00:02:34
We've been working with Pace since last October, so about 10 months.

AI Interviewer 00:02:40
Got it. Still relatively early in the relationship. Let's shift a bit to how you're actually using the product. What were the main pain points that led you to bring Pace on?

Expert 00:02:52
Again, we were launching a new strategy that required more back office operations than we were staffed for. We actually originally went to the traditional BPO market, business process outsourcing market, to try to find this back office support that we were lacking internally.

We also had, in parallel, a really strong agentic focus. We decided, "Hey, maybe there are." We actually found out that "Hey, there are some agentic-focused enterprises tackling the BPO space." Pace, for instance, calls themselves an AI BPO. We thought that "Hey, maybe it's worth giving them a look." After due diligence, we thought this was a path we wanted to go down.

AI Interviewer 00:03:34
Interesting. What specifically about the AI BPO approach made you choose Pace over a traditional BPO?

Expert 00:03:42
A number of things. I would say there's a greater transparency you're going to get from the AI BPO. You feel like you may be more in control of the processes. We felt that we'd validated the efficacy of the agents and their communication abilities. You get a dashboard where you can see an auditable trail of every conversation that they're having with clients and customers and brokers. **The price point at scale is competitively priced and better** priced than the human BPOs. It just aligns with our general company ethos of trying to be as AI forward as we can.

AI Interviewer 00:04:20
You mentioned the price point at scale. Can you expand on that? How does the pricing actually compare as you grow?

Expert 00:04:28
The pricing is usage-based with a floor. At scale, the task-by-task costs that **we estimated in years two, three, four lead to a significant reduction** as compared to traditional BPO models. BPO's goal of contracting is to tie themselves to GWP or tie themselves to premium growth. Typically, you're going to end up spending a bit more on that model than you would being able to actually track actions. Also, AI work compared to human work is cheaper.

AI Interviewer 00:04:59
That makes sense. How do you think about the return on investment so far? Is it meeting your expectations?

Expert 00:05:08
It's still to be determined. We are, as you said earlier, early-ish in the process. We haven't reached scale yet. The strategy's growth will define how much ROI we end up getting. As of now, it's still too early to tell. We've probably underutilized the tool at hand, but it's too early to call it a good or bad decision. Again, directionally, just on the tasks it has completed as compared to the even minimum floor **we would have paid for a BPO is already proving to be pretty good**.

AI Interviewer 00:05:43
You mentioned you've probably underutilized it so far. What's been holding back fuller utilization?

©2026, AlphaSense, Inc. All Rights Reserved. AlphaSense is a service mark of AlphaSense, Inc. All other trademarks mentioned belong to their respective owners.

Expert 00:05:51

Just the strategy it's tied to. It's, again, a new strategy for the company. It's a bet. It's had its own growth phase and growth trajectory. I think it has not reached scale yet. Until that strategy reaches full maturity and scale, **the Pace utilization will lag or it'll grow commensurate to the strategy itself.** It's not anything particularly related to Pace's tooling or how it's set up.

AI Interviewer 00:06:19

Got it. When you think about how you'd operate without Pace, what would that look like for your team?

Expert 00:06:25

Without Pace, we'd have to staff up on entry level or call center-like staff that would support the changes and challenges related to managing a large book of high volume, low premium value tasks. We would have to either staff up or find a different BPO.

AI Interviewer 00:06:42

If you had to put a rough dollar range on what you're spending with Pace annually, what ballpark would you say?

Expert 00:06:48

Ballpark is low six figures.

AI Interviewer 00:06:51

That's helpful. Moving on to the competitive landscape. When you were evaluating Pace, what other solutions did you look at?

Expert 00:07:01

Primarily, we were focused on the traditional BPO market when **we were initially looking at the problem** set we were facing. We vetted companies like Patra, FOCUS Insurance Services, Covenir, ReSource Pro, some of the traditional BPO players. We also thought and considered other agentic providers like FurtherAI, Strata, Effective AI, and a few others. Pace turned out to be the use case that made sense.

AI Interviewer 00:07:29

What specifically made Pace stand out over those other agentic providers you mentioned?

Expert 00:07:34

I think they were just more fit for purpose. Agentic BPO, they had built some of the workflows specifically that would mirror what a BPO would do. It just made, I think, logical sense even from just the way they marketed themselves and then through to how the workflows were set up. I think they were thinking, "Hey, we want to ***replace*** the need for a ***BPO***." We were looking at ***BPOs***, whereas some of the other ***agentic*** providers also have similar workflow capabilities. I just don't think they were thinking in the same vein. The holistic ***BPO replacement*** was a specific kind of use case that they met.

AI Interviewer 00:08:09

That's a clear differentiator. Where do you think Pace is significantly better than those competing products you evaluated and where might it be worse?

Expert 00:08:17

I think better or worse is maybe not the right way to think about it. I think they just have a different offering. I think every one of these agentic model providers are using the same models and are tackling the edge cases as they run across them. I think the edge case differentiation is one where I think these guys can differentiate themselves. I think knowing the fit for purpose workflows that your client is looking for day one is another element to differentiate yourself and showing confidence in the subject matter of insurance that can be quite complex and require confidence for governance and auditability and compliance. Those are areas that matter in these decisions.

AI Interviewer 00:08:59

Do you think Pace's advantages in those areas are growing or eroding over time as competitors catch up?

©2026, AlphaSense, Inc. All Rights Reserved. AlphaSense is a service mark of AlphaSense, Inc. All other trademarks mentioned belong to their respective owners.

Expert 00:09:06

I don't know that they're growing or eroding. I think this is to be seen what this entire AI revolution ends up looking like. I think there are plenty of operators who will always look to an external firm to solve these problems for them, although I think plenty of other organizations have started to train themselves on the underlying LLMs and how to deploy them within their organizations as well. I think the models will never be a differentiation point, but **the ability to have faced various challenges** and build around those particular edge cases and things like that will be what grows for Pace.

The challenge for them is that I think these tools are going to potentially become commoditized and fungible, it might end up being a race to the bottom on cost or a race against the build versus buy decision, where organizations might feel more confident over time deploying these tools themselves, especially as the models become smarter and smarter and require less edge case management and organizations get smarter about how to deploy five-coded workflows and things like that.

AI Interviewer 00:10:10

That's a really interesting perspective on commoditization. Is there anything a competitor could offer you today that would compel you to switch away from Pace?

Expert 00:10:20

Potentially. I think, again, it's not a decision **we're worried** about now, but if the costs grow exponentially or beyond the value that we think we could get from other providers or from building it ourselves, then sure. I don't think the solution is so differentiated that I see a competitor or ourselves being unable to replace it at a cheaper cost at some point in the future. I think **that's going to be the challenge for them**.

AI Interviewer 00:10:46

That makes a lot of sense. Let's shift gears a bit and talk about the broader market. How widespread do you think the adoption of solutions like Pace is across the insurance market today? Is it widespread or more untapped?

Expert 00:11:02

I think AI is definitely the number one priority for most organizations right now. I think it's more about the how. **I think there certainly is a lot more untapped TAM** than there is tapped TAM. I think at the same time, in parallel, there are organizations that are getting smarter about how they want to deploy these things. Do they want to go full force internal? Do they want to add a Pace? Do they want to add a workflow solution? Do they want to just arm their employees with Claude and Copilot? I think these are all being bucketed under the AI revolution, but I don't know that it's all going to go towards any one vendor.

I think there's a lot of competition in the space. I go to various conferences. Just in my day-to-day, I see and feel the amount of companies that are entering the same space that Pace exists within. I get pitched on at least two or three a day, five a week, something like that. **I think the challenge** is going to be that there are so many of these guys. How do they maintain the lead? What is the lead in the end?

AI Interviewer 00:12:10

Given **all that competition** you are describing, how hard do you think it would be for a start-up or a large existing company to come in and build a better version of what Pace does?

Expert 00:12:21

I don't know if it's better that I'd be worried about. I think cheaper is probably what I'd be worried about if I were them. I think they're doing a good job on accuracy, which is what people care about. **They're doing a good job on tackling these workflows**, but I think there are a lot of people doing that now, a lot of people tackling workflows. **I think the concern for them** should be more around, "Hey, someone's going to come do this and offer it at a 10th of the price by using open-source models or getting smarter around the deterministic versus LLM decision points and things like that. I think that's where the concern would be if I were them but better.

I think the outcomes that they're delivering have reached a point of accuracy and confidence that is probably a point of diminishing returns, but the next levels want to be seen. If it's a better version of what they're doing was your question, I think it's probably not going to be better. It's going to be that someone comes in and does it cheaper, which is what BPOs deal with. A traditional BPO is basically competing against outsourcing, competing against offshoring.

A BPO might say, "Hey, we're U.S.-based," which means you have U.S.-licensed people. Maybe you want to pay a little more because you want an English-speaking person on the phones and responding to your customers, and then an offshore is going to say, "Hey, we have people who are also licensed and really good at English. We do it cheaper." I think that's the dynamic of the BPO space that I think will end up extending to the AI workflow space eventually.

©2026, AlphaSense, Inc. All Rights Reserved. AlphaSense is a service mark of AlphaSense, Inc. All other trademarks mentioned belong to their respective owners.

AI Interviewer 00:13:55
That's a really compelling analogy. Let's move on to the buying process. Can you walk me through how the decision to bring Pace on actually came about?

Expert 00:14:05
We met the Pace team, Jamie and co, at a conference last fall, one of the largest conferences for program business called Target Markets. It was in the middle of our research process about the space and launch process for this new strategy. We were vetting them, as I mentioned, against traditional BPOs and traditional providers. They won out. They ended up being the tool that we ended up thinking would be useful for this particular strategy at the right price point. It, again, fit with our ethos of building agentically where we could.

The buying process then led to testing their tools, making sure that **we felt confidence around the voice agents**, the accuracy, etc. Finally, it was a pretty simple contracting process and implementation process that probably lasted a month and a half or two.

AI Interviewer 00:14:59
What were the key decision factors that ultimately tipped it in Pace's favor?

Expert 00:15:05
It just comes down to, again, fit for purpose, fit for the use case, fit for the strategy, **price point was good**, team seemed knowledgeable about insurance, etc.

AI Interviewer 00:15:14
You mentioned the team seemed knowledgeable about insurance. How important was that domain expertise in this decision?

Expert 00:15:22
It's very important. We found that **it can be frustrating to work with partners** that may have the latest and greatest technology but require a lot of handholding on the nuts and bolts of insurance. There are plenty of assumptions that can be made about how insurance works by the layman that are contrary to how insurance actually works. When you're deploying technology that's going to be customer interfacing or touching systems and processes **that are auditable and could turn into regulatory issues**, you need to be confident that the partner that you're entrusting this work to totally understands the space you're operating within and totally understands where the pitfalls might be.

AI Interviewer 00:16:02
That's a really important point. In terms of pricing structure, you mentioned usage-based with a floor earlier. Was that structure something Pace offered from the start or was it something you negotiated?

Expert 00:16:15
We negotiated towards the usage-based pricing. Their initial proposal, I believe, was more around a contract value-oriented mechanism, just, "Hey, you get all of this for X price a year license model." We wanted it to be commensurate to how much we were actually using it.

AI Interviewer 00:16:33
What did Pace ***replace***? Was it an existing ***BPO***, internal staff, or something else entirely?

Expert 00:16:41
They didn't replace anything. They were competing against those guys, but this was a brand-new strategy that didn't have any prior operational model behind it until we launched with Pace.

AI Interviewer 00:16:53
Got it. Let's talk about implementation. How did that process go? Were you involved in it?

Expert 00:17:02
Yes. It was pretty straightforward. Fortunately, they had a lot of the workflows already designed. What required refinement was that last mile of how exactly we work, how exactly our SOPs are designed. We both modified or refined the workflows to fit our business model, our

©2026, AlphaSense, Inc. All Rights Reserved. AlphaSense is a service mark of AlphaSense, Inc. All other trademarks mentioned belong to their respective owners.

operating model. They also needed to get integrated into our suite of tools that these agents would need to work within and input data, extract data, etc. It was an integration process as well as a workflow SOP communication journey.

AI Interviewer 00:17:37
Roughly how long did that full implementation take from start to go live?

Expert 00:17:43
I think about a month and a half, I would say, a month and a half of back and forth, multiple meetings a week, testing, etc.

AI Interviewer 00:17:52
What resources were required on your end to get through that implementation? Was it mostly your team or did you need technical resources or third parties involved?

Expert 00:18:03
Mostly our team and Pace, so no IT resources were required necessarily. We did need them to collaborate with the external tools we were using. They had to integrate with things like the policy admin system and the CRM system and things like that to make sure the agent could work in those tools if the connectors didn't already exist. I guess it was a combo of our internal team and the external vendors they needed to integrate with.

AI Interviewer 00:18:30
That sounds relatively smooth. Let's talk about service quality. How would you describe your overall experience with Pace as a vendor in terms of support and responsiveness?

Expert 00:18:42
I would say they're very responsive. They're quick to modify things as needed. They're quick to educate where there are gaps of knowledge internally. I think they do a good job of service levels and making product manipulations as we come up with them.

AI Interviewer 00:18:57
Is there anything specific they could do to improve your satisfaction with their service?

Expert 00:19:03
No. There's nothing that we're looking for from them right now. We're mainly focused on just growing this particular strategy.

AI Interviewer 00:19:13
Good to hear. Let's move on to renewal. Have you renewed your agreement with Pace yet or is that coming up?

Expert 00:19:20
We signed a multi-year agreement, so renewal is not something we're concerned with at this time.

AI Interviewer 00:19:25
Do you expect your spend with Pace to change over the next two to three years?

Expert 00:19:30
Yes, so long as the strategy continues to grow, **the usage-based pricing should grow commensurate with the strategy**.

AI Interviewer 00:19:38
Is there anything you think Pace should be selling you that they aren't today?

©2026, AlphaSense, Inc. All Rights Reserved. AlphaSense is a service mark of AlphaSense, Inc. All other trademarks mentioned belong to their respective owners.

Expert 00:19:42

I think for them, they should continue to think about other things that BPOs provide that they currently aren't. There are a lot of paper document processes and print and mail and billing and check lockboxes and things like that that you might expect a traditional BPO to also support. I only have to assume that they want to dominate the BPO market. I think they should continue to explore other things that BPOs do and build where they can. Compliance, billing, print, mail, etc., I think those are areas where they could continue to expand their offerings.

AI Interviewer 00:20:17

That's a really interesting perspective. Let's shift to product stickiness. What would it actually take for you to switch away from Pace to a competing solution?

Expert 00:20:28

I think if there's some step change outcome deliverable that these workflows start to identify that they can perform, I can't honestly think of what that is right this second, but if there are some step change outcomes that a different provider starts saying, "Hey, not only are we able to service clients, but we're creating even more stickiness," or there's some sort of gamification. I honestly couldn't tell you right this second.

Maybe if there's additional benefit beyond replacing a back office, which is what we're asking them to do. I would say beyond that, we would probably stick with them, and then it's going to come down, again, the same way you would vet a BPO spend versus another BPO spend. If there's another BPO that's going to do it cheaper, then obviously we would listen for the same value or for the same services.

AI Interviewer 00:21:17

How hard do you think it would actually be to switch? What would the switching costs look like?

Expert 00:21:23

I don't think it would be that hard, personally. All the data is living within our existing systems. If they were able to stand up their solution in a month and a half, I assume that the next vendor would be able to do the same or better. We might have more data to transfer at that time. That would be the biggest lift, but I assume connectors would solve a lot of that. I don't necessarily think it's necessarily the stickiest relationship from that standpoint.

AI Interviewer 00:21:52

What price increase, percentage-wise, would push you to start seriously looking at alternatives?

Expert 00:21:59

Anything more than 3%-5% a year would probably at least be worth taking a look at. If we're starting to talk about 10%, 15%, 20% increase for the same usage, I think we'd have to take a better look at that and understand why because the models themselves, tokens are getting cheaper. It would be a curious movement if we started seeing increases when models are getting cheaper. If they start routing everything through fable to get more of a spend, then that wouldn't make sense.

AI Interviewer 00:22:33

Absolutely. Understanding the rationale behind any price changes would be crucial. Let's talk about NPS for a moment. How would you score Pace on a scale of 1-10? What are the top three reasons for that score?

Expert 00:22:48

I'd give them a seven or eight. There's nothing they're doing wrong. I think they've done a good job. I think they do what they say they do. The AI workflows are working. I'll give them a seven or eight.

AI Interviewer 00:23:04

What would they need to do to get to a 10 in your view?

Expert 00:23:08

I think if they start pushing our thinking in certain ways of how these agentic workflows could, whether it is generate more business or do things that we're not expecting it to do and surprise us with added value, then I'd be willing to give it a nine or 10. For now, they're doing

©2026, AlphaSense, Inc. All Rights Reserved. AlphaSense is a service mark of AlphaSense, Inc. All other trademarks mentioned belong to their respective owners.

what we expect them to do. It's good, but I would say for a nine or 10, it needs to be something that we don't expect **them to do or there are new ways that other competitors** are deploying AI that we haven't thought of that they could help us with.

AI Interviewer 00:23:39

That makes a lot of sense. Exceeding expectations rather than just meeting them. We're getting close to wrapping up. Are you excited about your future with Pace?

Expert 00:23:50

I'm excited about the future of AI workflows broadly and how they're going to redefine our businesses and the businesses of our MGAs. Future with Pace, to be seen. I'm not excited, but I think I'm expecting it to go well. I would need to be, again, surprised for it to become more exciting than what my baseline expectation is.

AI Interviewer 00:24:13

Thank you for taking the time to speak with me. Have a nice day.

©2026, AlphaSense, Inc. All Rights Reserved. AlphaSense is a service mark of AlphaSense, Inc. All other trademarks mentioned belong to their respective owners.